

Marmalade-almond stuffed french toast

Here is proof a prolific breakfast dish can be made with or without dairy or eggs. The tofu filling is simple and **Creamy**; the batter contains flax seeds, banana, and soy milk or rice milk. Choose between vegan batter and the more traditional egg batter that follows.

TOAST

1 pound [500g] stale or lightly toasted semolina, French, or Italian bread, or enough to make 8 slices, cut 1 inch thick [2.5cm]

6 ounces soft tofu, drained and pressed of water [180g]

3 tablespoons orange marmalade

2 tablespoons maple syrup

½ teaspoon almond extract

Pinch of salt

VEGAN BATTER

1½ cups plain or vanilla rice milk or soy milk [375ml]

1 tablespoon plus 1 teaspoon flax seeds

½ teaspoon vanilla extract

1 ripe banana, sliced

1 tablespoon maple syrup

½ teaspoon cinnamon, plus more for dusting

Pinch of salt

Vegetable oil, for frying

TRADITIONAL EGG BATTER

8 egg whites or whole free-range eggs

1 cup vanilla soy milk or rice milk [250ml]

4 tablespoons butter [60g]

½ teaspoon cinnamon

Maple syrup, cinnamon, and/or fresh fruit, as accompaniment

1. Using a sharp paring knife, gently **cut** out a center block from the flat crust side of each bread slice. Set aside.
2. In a food processor, **combine** the tofu, marmalade, maple syrup, almond extract, and salt. Blend until very smooth, 2 to 3 minutes, scraping down the sides once or twice. If you have time, prepare the tofu filling ahead and let it rest an hour or so to pick up more flavor.

3. With a pastry bag or a small spoon, **pipe** about 1 tablespoon tofu mixture into each bread hollow. Smooth out with the back of the spoon.

preparing vegan batter

1. In a blender, **combine** ½ cup [125ml] of the milk and the flax seeds and blend until the seeds break apart and are very well dispersed, about 3 minutes. Be patient with this. Scrape down the sides several times. The finished product will be somewhat like egg whites: thick and foamy.
2. **Add** the remaining milk, vanilla extract, banana, maple syrup, cinnamon, and salt and blend again for another 30 seconds or so. Follow the same procedures as below for dipping, cooking, and garnishing, except use oil instead of butter.

preparing traditional egg batter

1. **Whisk** the eggs and milk in a bowl until blended.
2. Heat half of the butter in a large frying pan over medium heat. **Dip** each slice of bread in the egg-milk mixture, coating both sides generously.
3. Arrange 3 or 4 slices of bread in the pan and **cook** until golden brown on both sides, 2 to 3 minutes for each side. Repeat procedure with remaining butter and bread. Serve warm with maple syrup. Garnish with cinnamon and fruit.

SERVES 4

note For best results when using vegan batter, use a nonstick pan. Regular soft or even firm tofu is probably your best bet for the filling. Silken is a little too soft and will spill out more easily. A pastry bag works best for piping in the filling. Buy disposable bags if you don't have a regular pastry bag.